

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of aspects of Philosophy and Ethics in the context of Islam as a lived religion within the United Kingdom and throughout the world.

There are two sections: Arguments for the Existence of Allah; Religious Teachings on Relationships and Families in the 21st Century.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs, issues and practices to Muslims today should be explored throughout the two sections. This should include reference to how the Qur'an informs a Muslim's understanding of the topics and how approaches to the issues are underpinned by philosophical arguments and ethical theory as applicable.

Students will be expected to study Islam within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian. Students should recognise that Islam is one of the many religions and world views in Great Britain, which include Buddhism, Hinduism, Judaism, Sikhism and non-religious views such as Humanism and atheism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should compare and contrast the areas of ethics and/or philosophy within Islam with non-religious views as outlined in the content below.

Students should also recognise that within Islam there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within Islam in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Sunni and Shi'a traditions.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	Revelation as proof of the existence of Allah; the Qur'an as revelation; revelation as shown in the Qur'an as direct (Surah 34:46–50) or through a messenger; divergent understandings of what revelation shows about the nature of Allah for Muslims.
1.2	Visions as proof of the existence of Allah: the nature and importance of visions in Islam; Qur'anic examples of visions, including Surah 19:16–22; reasons why they might lead to belief in the existence of Allah, and Muslim responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) which maintain that visions are hallucinations and provide no proof that Allah exists; divergent understandings of what visions show about the nature of Allah for Muslims, with reference to Sunni, Shi'a and Sufi Islam.
1.3	Miracles as proof of the existence of Allah: the nature and importance of miracles in Islam; the Qur'an as a miracle, including Surah 17:84–89; examples of miracles; reasons why they might lead to belief in the existence of Allah; Muslim responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) which maintain that miracles can be scientifically explained and provide no proof that Allah exists; divergent understandings of what miracles show about the nature of Allah for Muslims.
1.4	Muslim attitudes towards religious experiences and their use as philosophical arguments for the existence of Allah: the nature of a religious experience; Surah 2:118; divergent understandings of the nature and importance of religious experiences in Islam, with reference to Sunni, Shi'a and Sufi Islam; Muslim responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments that religious experiences do not provide proof that Allah exists.
1.5	Design argument: the design argument and its use in Islam as a philosophical argument for the existence of Allah and what it shows about the nature of Allah; divergent understandings of the nature and importance of the design argument for the existence of Allah in Islam, including reference to Surah 2:164; Muslim responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments against the design argument as evidence for the existence of Allah.
1.6	Cosmological argument: the cosmological argument and its use in Islam as a philosophical argument for the existence of Allah, including reference to kalam in the writings of al-Ghazali, including <i>Kitab al-Iqtisad fil'I'tiqad</i> ; what the cosmological argument shows about the nature of Allah; divergent understandings of the strengths and challenges of the cosmological argument in Islam; Muslim responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments against the cosmological argument as evidence for the existence of Allah.
1.7	Issues raised by existence of suffering and Allah as compassionate, including Surah 1: the problems the existence of suffering may raise for Muslims about the nature of Allah; how the problem and its basis as a philosophical argument may lead some people to reject belief in Allah or cause believers to question their belief.
1.8	The different practical and philosophical solutions offered to the problem of suffering and Allah as compassionate within Islam: Qur'anic, including Surah 2:151–177; theoretical and practical responses, including life as a test, prayer and charity; divergent understandings within Islam of their success in solving the problem.